

Eritrea(/country/eri)

Eritrea: ICC Weekly Update for 10 Jun 2000

Situation Report

Source: [Info. Co-ordination Centre\(/organization/info-co-ordination-centre\)](#)

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Jeffrey L. Shannon

Eritrean Development Foundation

Asmara, ERITREA

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Population concentrations (estimates to date): ERREC Emergency Appeal

ERREC has just released an Appeal for Emergency Humanitarian Assistance to War and Drought Victims in Eritrea, which targets 1,665,000 people, representing approximately 50% of the Eritrean population.

The appeal deals with food, shelter, agricultural input, health, water and sanitation, transport and logistical support in addition to environmental considerations.

The total financial requirement to meet the needs of the target population amounts to US \$183,000,000.

ERREC Emergency Appeal

Deb'at	50,000	stabilized
Harena	45,000	growing
Salina	55,000	growing
Adi Keshi	40,000	growing
Adi Keshi	40,000	growing
Adi Keshi	40,000	growing
Adi Keshi	40,000	growing

Umkulu Reception Center (Northern Red Sea)	6,000	some absorbed into host communities potential for growth
Sudan border	73,000 (refugees registered)	unstable some returning

BACKGROUND

The two areas most affected by the war, Gash-Barka and Debub, vary in terms of the IDP situation. With the reclaiming of wide areas of Gash-Barka and the gradual removal of Ethiopian forces from that area, the situation has entered a new phase.

Continued Ethiopian presence and shelling in the Debub zone continues to fuel displacement and hinder humanitarian activities.

Large numbers of IDPs and local populations remain scattered and on the move in insecure areas. Some 65% of the affected population are children and 25% women.

There are continued reports of unaccompanied children whose parents have either been killed in shelling or have been separated in the process of displacement. Actions must be undertaken to locate and reunite families where possible as well as to provide special care for those children newly orphaned by the conflict.

GASH-BARKA/ANSEBA

The estimated population in Gash-Barka is 508,000, with the number of persons directly affected by war, drought and displacement standing between 450,000 and 470,000.

The situation in Gash-Barka is very fluid due to recent military developments, with local populations scattered over a very wide area or still on the move. However, approximately 50,000 IDPs from Gash-Barka have settled in Deb-B9at camp near Keren in Anseba region. Additional IDPs have been absorbed by host villages and towns.

There is a great deal of concern about sanitation due to the heavy concentrations of IDPs in this camp, although they have been spread out as widely as possible within the camp. In addition, various donors are providing latrines and clean water, thus ameliorating the situation. However, the possibility of sanitation problems remains.

With the change in the military situation, aid can now move more freely to Tessenei and possibly to the Guluj area, though areas farther south remain uncertain and mostly inaccessible.

There are reports of some civilians re-turning to their home villages and towns to assess the damage to property and the possibility of resettlement (see box). The danger of mines remains paramount in those areas, but we should explore the possibility of providing logistical support to enable the return of those who wish to do so.

DEBUB

Debub is far more densely populated than Gash-Barka (739,300), thus exacerbating the IDP situation. Many areas are still occupied, with heavy shelling continuing in other areas.

A large number of IDPs are in hiding, while the two IDP camps, Harena and Salina, continue to grow and remain unstable. ERREC is currently initiating efforts to document displacement areas and human rights violations.

ERREC and WFP have managed to deliver some food to the Areza and Mai Dima areas as some IDPs return, though it remains unsafe with the fluid military situation.

Infrastructural damage has been great, as in Gash-Barka, with pharmacies, clinics, housing and shops destroyed, and food and goods looted or rendered unusable.

Emergency food supplies are the greatest need, in addition to shelter within the IDP camps as the numbers continue to grow.

It is far too early to speak of safe resettlement in home villages and towns, but with private housing destroyed in this area, temporary housing will be a necessity, even after the cessation of hostilities and for some time to come.

Cooking utensils remain a great need in all areas.

The needs in Harena and Salina camps are the same as in Deb=B9at, but have not been as well supplied and existing aid cannot keep up with the quickly growing numbers.

Positive Developments:

- Reclaiming by Eritrea of Barentu, Tessenei, Guluj, which may allow return of IDPs -- tentative movement of small number of civilians
- Possibility of aid provision in very near future to Tokombia and Om Hajer -- to be followed up
- Relative stabilizing of situation for IDPs in Deb=B9at camp
- Areza and Mai Dima reclaimed and receiving some aid

Areas of Concern:

- Rains approaching -- plowing/planting season very near -- IDPs need to be home; need plowing, seeds, shelter and emergency food

- Immediate need of food, temporary shelter and kitchen utensils in camps and home villages destroyed by recent developments
- Continued shelling of some areas in the south
- Mining in western lowlands presents a serious danger to returnees

Resettlement

With the retaking by Eritrean forces of certain areas in the western lowlands (Barentu, Tessenei, and Gulu), it may become possible for IDPs to return to those areas. With the approaching rainy season, it will become imperative to enable farmers to resume agricultural activities if at all possible. Otherwise, long-term aid requirements will increase several fold.

One major concern is the continued shelling of towns and villages near the front, in addition to the possibility of widespread mining.

Some civilians are tentatively returning to home villages to assess damages and the possibility of return. Should return be possible, the donor community will need to be ready to supply emergency food and temporary shelter for those whose homes have been destroyed. Returnees will also need agricultural supplies such as seeds, draught animals, farming tools and tractors to allow immediate resumption of plowing and planting.

One suggestion is to set up distribution centers along easily accessible points in those areas.

The main area of concern at this moment is Gash-Barka which is typically responsible for up to 50% of all agricultural output.

Adi Keshi is being resettled with people returning from Forto and new IDPs from the Tokombia area, in addition to those who stayed; while the water pump generator was undamaged, water pipes supplied by Oxfam have been destroyed; camp population has now reached 40,000 and emergency provision of food, shelter and water is extremely urgent.

A new camp is being established in Alba (between Adi Keih and Segeneiti), composed of former IDPs from Mai Wurai, Filho and other areas; emergency food is a priority; population numbers are not yet available.

ERREC offices have been established in Adi Keshi, Molki, Tessenei, and Haicotta and have begun operation, beginning with the supply of emergency food.

ICC is now able to arrange assessment visits to tentative IDP sites around Adi Keih, which are currently in need of emergency assistance.

IDPs near Adi Quala are again on the move.

Around 50% of Agordet=B9s population have returned to the town and are settling in.

About ICC

ICC's main aim is to facilitate a rapid and efficient response to the humanitarian crisis in Eritrea, in coordination with ERREC. Among other activities, ICC will encourage and coordinate the exchange of information among the donor community to help achieve this aim.

ICC operates under the auspices of the ERREC commissioner and the UN resident coordinator. Its office is located in ERREC.

ICC is supported with human and material resources by: ERREC, OCHA/UNDAC, UNICEF, NCA, and EDF.

Contact People:

Yemane Tekleyohannes, ERREC

Ivo Freijssen, OCHA

Tel. 18 22 22, ext. 217 fax. 18 29 70

This is the ICC's first weekly update and in order for this continuing effort to be more helpful for all donor organizations, we will need your timely input regarding figures, camp conditions, developments, shortfalls, needs and concerns. Please send relevant information to the ICC office located in ERREC by Thursday of each week for inclusion into the update. Suggestions for improvement are very welcome.

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Sources: [Amnesty\(/organization/amnesty\)](#), [CIVICUS\(/organization/civicus\)](#), [CPJ\(/organization/cpj\)](#), + 4 more

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